

## Service level objectives

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# What you promise, and what you refuse to promise.

An SLO is not a quality metric. It is a switch that stops feature work. The error budget is the mechanism that makes the promise real.

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Presenter · Team

Internal review

### IN THIS DECK

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02 / THE SWITCH

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03 / THE BUDGET

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04 / THE EXCLUSIONS

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05 / THE FAILURE MODES

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06 / THE DECISIONS

# An SLO is not a quality metric. It is a switch.

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## READ AS A METRIC

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It describes how the service behaved.

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It gets reported, compared, discussed.

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Nothing about next week has to change.

## USED AS A SWITCH

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It has two positions and only two.

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Crossing it changes what ships next.

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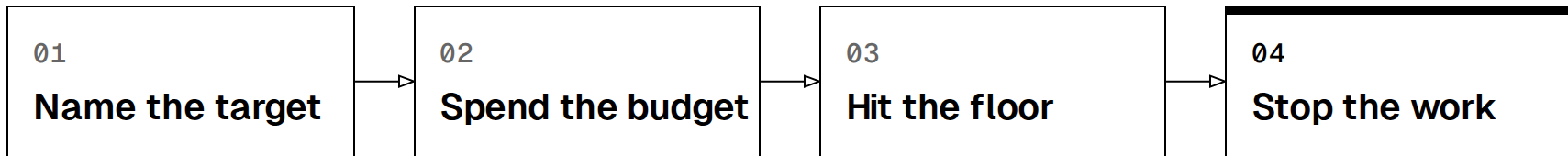
No meeting is needed for it to fire.

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**A target that has never stopped anything is a dashboard with a threshold drawn on it.**

# The error budget is the part that actually stops work

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## WHAT MAKES IT A BUDGET

Every failed request draws down the same account. Nobody has to agree that the service is bad — the account has already said so, and it says so the same way every week.

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## WHAT MAKES IT A SWITCH

Reaching the floor is not a discussion item. It is the condition on a rule written before anyone was upset, and a rule spent with no consequence was never a rule.

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**A budget nobody spends was never a promise.**

## The exclusions are the promise, written down

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| AXIS      | IN THE PROMISE                | OUT, BY NAME                    |
|-----------|-------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| SURFACE   | The path a user is waiting on | Internal jobs nobody waits on   |
| FAULT     | What our own edge can observe | The client's network and device |
| CALENDAR  | The ordinary week             | A declared maintenance window   |
| OWNERSHIP | What this service itself does | What a dependency promises      |

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**An exclusion you never wrote down becomes an argument during the incident.**

# Three ways an SLO stops being a switch

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The number stays exactly where it was. What goes missing is the rule attached to it.

01

## A target nobody chose

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It came off a vendor page.  
Nobody in the room would  
defend it, so nobody  
enforces it either.

02

## A budget with no teeth

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The chart turns red, the  
sprint carries on, and the  
budget quietly becomes a  
colour.

03

## An exception each time

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Every breach arrives with a  
good reason. A switch that  
bends has only one  
position.

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**Each of these is a decision nobody wrote down, showing up later as a habit.**

# What we need to decide

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## 01 What actually stops

Name the work that halts when the budget is gone, and the work that does not.

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## 02 Who declares it

One role who can say the budget is gone without convening anyone.

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## 03 What we refuse to promise

The exclusions, written down before the first incident asks for them.

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**Until these three are answered, we have a metric — and metrics stop nothing.**